

EYEWITNESS May 4, 1970

Horror at Kent State

In demonstrations that started on May 1, 1970, students marched, damaged businesses, and burned the old ROTC building at Kent State University, Ohio, in protest over the perceived expansion of the war into Cambodia. By Monday, May 4, armed National Guardsmen occupied the campus. Tom Grace, a sophomore on the way to a history exam, was caught up in the tragedy that followed.

The students felt that it was their campus and they were doing nothing wrong, and that the armed National Guardsmen had no right to order them to disperse. Many students screamed at them to get off their campus. At the same time, some students were wandering through the area with textbooks, unaware of what was taking place around them.

All of a sudden, the National Guardsmen got to the top of the hill where they began to fire rifles. Tom Grace describes turning and running as fast as he could, before being knocked off his feet by a bullet through his left heel. There was no cover and farther down the hill in the parking lot, he could see people were dropping. He didn't know if they were being hit by bullets or if they were just hugging the ground.

“ It ... kept going and going and going. And I remember thinking, ‘When is this going to stop?’”

TOM GRACE, ORAL HISTORY IN *FROM CAMELOT TO KENT STATE: THE SIXTIES EXPERIENCE IN THE WORDS OF THOSE WHO LIVED IT*, 1987